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George Avakian

Producer/historian George Avakian has played a major role in the development of jazz and popular music in America. He was born in Armenia in 1919 and immigrated with his family to the U.S. While a student at Yale, he produced the pioneering documentary jazz album "Chicago Jazz" while also entering the field of jazz journalism. During his career he has produced albums with many of the greatest artists in jazz, including Miles Davis, Dave Brubeck and Louis Armstrong. His writing on music has appeared in Down Beat, Esquire *and* Metronome *magazines and he remains an important source for historical information about the history of recording in the U.S. and abroad.*

George was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 21, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming at Hamilton College today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and it's a great honor to have George Avakian with me, who is one of the country's most renown record producers and an absolute wealth of knowledge about American music, not only jazz but especially jazz.

GA: That's what comes with being around on the scene and being interested you know.

MR: You had mentioned Marshall Stearns as a very important person in your life.

GA: Absolutely. Marshall Stearns was a graduate school student. We all thought he was a college professor because he had a byline that gave 20 Lake Place, New Haven, Connecticut as the place to write to him about questions about jazz and so forth. But to my surprise when I enrolled as a freshman in 1937 I found that he was living just off campus with his wife and going to the graduate school to get a Ph.D. in English Literature. And the great discovery was that Marshall not only had a superb record collection but he had an open house every Friday night for anyone who wanted to come and listen to records and talk and exchange ideas. So having been invited to come anytime, for the two years that it took for Marshall to finish up his Ph.D., I was in his home almost every Friday night, mainly with a classmate named Jerry King, who was also an enthusiastic young collector. And we heard the whole history of jazz really in that great collection he had, which filled I would say five rather wide shelves, and it was carefully catalogued and the collection ended up at the Rutgers Institute of Jazz 'cause Marshall wanted to establish a center for study, research and so forth, and that's what he chose to do. And as I go through the collection of 78s, I quickly recognize on the corner of these heavy green paper jackets the writing on the labels, the clear handwriting is mine and the not-so-easy-to-read handwriting is Jerry's. But he called us all brownies, because whenever he had a number of review records to go through, he kept the ones that he

wanted of course and he asked us to make out the labels, and so that's how it came about that there are two years worth of labels made out by King and Avakian.

MR: And you said this was about what year? What span?

GA: '37 to the summer of '39, the Fall of '37 when I went to Yale as a freshman. And in that period, Marshall wanted to cut back on some of his writing for magazines and so he let me take over part of his writing at *Tempo Magazine*, which was later taken over by *Down Beat*. So I did the Collector's Corner and I got letters addressed to Professor Avakian, although I was only, well I guess I really started toward the end of my freshman year, and it kind of shocked me, because here I was an enthusiastic young collector and I thought I knew a lot about jazz but knew that it was small compared to Marshall. But Marshall encouraged me. He said, "George look, you can do it, you've got the texts" which were the only ones available. They consisted of the French edition of Hugues Panassié's *La Jazz Hot*, and Charles Delaunay's classic *Hot Discography*, he literally invented the word when he compiled these incredible lists organized in a very easy to follow fashion, in a little book, pocket sized, which was great for record collectors of course, that made the first listing of personnel, dates, master numbers, the release numbers including foreign countries, because after all he did it in France but he was always careful whenever possible to put the American release numbers first. And that 1938 edition, which was Delaunay's third edition, was my reference guide when Columbia Records asked me to come in and organize their files of classic jazz, which they knew existed on their shelves but for the most part were not specifically identified except by master numbers. And so using Delaunay as the basis and adding my own information which I sometimes pasted into that book, or I kept it in notebooks along with my regular class notes, I was able to find a lot of material that was worthy of the first reissue program that included albums as well as single records. Before that there had been some haphazard single reissues in England and France mainly on the continent and the United States, especially the companies that had the catalogues, Victor Records and — well it wasn't Columbia Records at the time, it was really known as Brunswick and Vocalion. That was the American recording corporation, which ended up being the company that kept gathering up the masters of companies that failed or were easily bought out. And eventually CBS bought American Record Corporation and made Columbia the principal label. It had been mainly a classical label through the years after the blue label pop records died out in the middle of the depression.

MR: It's curious when you look at the music at that time, you were doing a jazz history, but the history of jazz wasn't that old.

GA: No it certainly wasn't. Because jazz didn't really get to be known particularly until about World War I and at that time it was really peppy dance music and novelty music and of

course the Original Dixieland Jass Band, which I never had too much respect for I'm sorry to say, but I thought of it as an entertainment group, and that's what they really were, even though they came out of New Orleans and obviously picked up a lot of what they heard on the streets and the cafes of New Orleans in the period before the war. The real burgeoning of jazz, and it spread across the country, came about after the war, and in the early 20s recordings had a good deal to do with it because that way it was possible for musicians who couldn't travel too extensively in those days. I mean today travel is nothing, but it wasn't so easy back then, even when I was in school. And the result was that through records, musicians could get to hear musicians in other cities, even though they didn't get there. Another thing that happened was that there was a certain amount of interplay when bands traveled, let's say from the middle west to New York, and then the word got back when they came home that hey, you know who I heard in New York, and you know you can get records by this guy. The great original influence of all time I guess was Louis Armstrong, who started recording in 1925 on his own.

MR: I have a quote from you here: it said, "The most important thing in jazz history was Louis Armstrong spreading his music through LPs." You said this yesterday.

GA: Oh I did, okay, I was going to say gee, when did I say that because he started before LPs.

MR: Yes certainly it was before LPs, but the idea of him spreading through recording.

GA: Well that's absolutely true, because people got to know the history of jazz that way, through LPs even more than those 78s that I just talked about, that started around 1940. And the fact that it was an organized series meant that people knew that they could expect another release the following month, and that way they were on the lookout. And the annotations that I wrote for the 78 RPM albums were the first group of written documentation of the careers of some of these performers, because before that there weren't books on jazz, and what there was was — well, there just weren't many. I always felt that the earliest books of Robert Goffin's book in Belgium were rather skimpy and he was writing as an enthusiast, and then when Panassié wrote his book, I don't remember, it was published I think in 1936, he too was an enthusiast but he did it in a very organized way because he broke it up into chapters, by subject, and then in each chapter he made references to records and there were footnotes giving personnel other than what was mentioned in the text, and what was also important, the release catalogue numbers and dates of recording so that it was already a little bit discographical. And Delaunay and Panassié worked very closely together interviewing American musicians who got to France and these Americans like Coleman Hawkins, Benny Carter and even Armstrong himself and eventually Duke Ellington in the late 30s, were extremely important in terms of the information that they furnished the jazz fans in France and in England particularly. The important thing also was that these fans were already quite knowledgeable for a

rather special reason that I didn't catch on to at first, which was that the American jazz records that got released abroad tended to stay in the catalogues. They didn't sell very widely and the record business was smaller in Europe than it was in America, and because they stayed in the catalogues they were there for reference as more and more people got interested in the historical recordings of the 1920s and early 30s. In America they got cut out rather quickly because there was so much of an emphasis on the hits of the immediate time.

MR: Gee it's almost like today with pop music, how quickly an artist can come and go, or a particular song, you know, its longevity.

GA: It's always been that way, always has been, and that's the difference about jazz because it does have longevity since the music has a foundation and a quality which doesn't change. There are of course changes of taste in jazz that happen all the time, and it's unfortunate that the young people of today are not too interested in going back into the foundation of the music that they listen to because the foundation is not only fascinating but it's very important for a complete understanding of the music that has come along in later years.

MR: When you say jazz has a foundation and a quality that doesn't change, is it possible to put into words what that quality is?

GA: Oh no, not really, and I'll tell you it's the old story of either Fats Waller or Louis Armstrong having told a lady, "Lady, if you don't know what jazz is, you'll never know" something like that. I asked both of them, did you really say that? And they laughed and said who knows? And Louis had one expression that he would use every now and then when someone asked him a question like that, which was, "Yeah, yeah, man, something like that." Like the story of how scat singing began, when he dropped the music on the "Heebee Jeebees" and knocked heads with the producer, Richard M. Jones, and straightened up and just started scatting. Jones told me that story and I didn't quite believe it because it's a little too slick on the record, you can tell it's not really an accident. So I asked Louis about that and he said, "Yeah, something like that." And he would tell that story himself and he would always give a deprecating chuckle you know.

MR: Yeah. That's a good all-purpose term. And you were saying something yesterday I thought was really fascinating about how instrumentalists copied vocalists and how vocalists copied instrumentalists. And you had this kind of round about pattern.

GA: Absolutely. Well Armstrong is a great illustration because he sings the way he plays the trumpet, and he plays as a trumpet player like a singer. And you know he always stressed that he got his lyrical style of playing trumpet by listening to operatic arias. His great favorites were Caruso and John McCormack. And if you make comparisons, it's easy to see that the lyric quality of these great operatic tenors is absolutely part and parcel Armstrong style. He's the great lyric interpreter on an instrument, just as the vocalists of

the early part of the century who made the earliest records have preserved the history of singing up to that point.

MR: Yeah if you listen to "West End Blues" I think that's all you need to hear to back up that statement.

GA: Yup. And it's interesting on "West End Blues" he uses that wordless vocal in the latter part of the recording, which is perfectly in keeping with what he has played. I love that record as an example of Armstrong as the complete lyric performer and the great technician as well. The fact that he sings a vocal that has no words is completely fitting to that aspect of his work, because the words don't make any difference and he treats the words like that in many of his vocal performances. And yet when he wants to sing a song and get across a message, Frank Sinatra, Bing Crosby, Ella Fitzgerald, they've all said there was nobody like Armstrong and they all copied and learned from him.

MR: Do you suppose that performance, and especially that introduction was completely spontaneous?

GA: No I don't think so. I never talked to Louis about that, but I'm sure — man as I get older I get hoarser talking, talking — I'm sure that he had a pattern worked out, just as you can hear in the many, many performances of things that he did constantly in performances, broadcasts and so forth. The British trumpet player Humphrey Lyttelton wrote a very good piece many years ago about the people who say oh he just plays the same solo over and over again. And he pointed out that he certainly does not and he cited examples on records and he said the pattern was worked out but within it, the variation is endless. And that's very true of all musicians really. If you study even let's say someone like John Coltrane, who was a very spontaneous performer, he had things worked out, just as all musicians have, because jazz isn't simply spontaneous improvisation, it's improvisation within a framework. And the framework is very important when you have an ensemble going. The early New Orleans bands had no soloists to speak of in their performances. Occasionally there would be a clarinet solo, and I always thought it was to relieve the pressure on the brass players because New Orleans jazz really grew more out of the parade, outdoors music than anything else. And that was a heavy burden for those guys blowing those instruments and blowing them hard for hours on end.

MR: When you were doing this research in your early years of listening, did you start in your mind to be able to categorize things? Like when you heard something did you think of it as New Orleans jazz or Chicago style, or was there a difference between black and white bands for instance that you could hear?

GA: Well there was in the sense that in the earlier days of jazz, black musicians and white musicians tended not to play together in public. And that included phonograph records for quite a while, although as we all know from the memoirs of everybody from

Armstrong on down, after hours was a different situation. But the division even stayed on records for quite a long time, although it was broken in small ways like Jelly Roll Morton playing with the New Orleans Rhythm Kings on that record in 1922 I believe or '23. And that I think happened because Jelly Roll's music was published by Melrose Brothers in Chicago, and the New Orleans Rhythm Kings also placed publications with Melrose and so it was a natural thing that Jelly Roll would participate in some of these performances of the copyrights on records. On records also there is some infiltration you might say took place like Eddie Condon playing with Louis Armstrong on the famous "Knocking The Jug" session and then on the same day they did "I Can't Give You Anything But Love," and there's Condon playing banjo with an all-black orchestra. And this continued with things like Condon again playing with Fats Waller on the famous five piece band session of "Minor Drag" and what was the other side, I keep forgetting the title. In any case the labels got reversed which was so spectacularly goofed up on Victor's part, so that "Minor Drag" is a very fast tune and the other side is—

MR: Some kind of blues thing.

GA: But it doesn't matter. And the great breakthrough came about in the middle 30s when Benny Goodman hired Teddy Wilson to play as a member of the first Goodman trio that started on records actually. But Goodman decided we're going to do this in person. So what he did was to play a set and maybe twice an evening, they would do this at the end of the set there would be a brief break and out would come the trio with Teddy replacing Jess Stacy on piano and Gene Krupa returning to the drums, and they would play maybe three numbers. And when Benny saw that this was succeeding, and believe me it wasn't easy because he was told by people who were in charge at the hotels where he began this, the first one I think was in Chicago, and at first they say, "You can't do that." And Benny said, "Well I'm going to, fire me if you want to. He added Lionel Hampton on vibraphone, and the Goodman quartet was formed. And it all began with records first and then Benny, who was a very determined person as we all know from the anecdotes, forced the integration on stage. And when this happened, the situation where Gene Krupa left shortly, I think it was February 1938, Benny immediately had Hampton play drums with the band, which caused a bit of a stir again. He got that established and from then on it kept happening more and more. Roy Eldridge played with Gene Krupa and before that I think he was with Artie Shaw for a while. Artie Shaw hired Billie Holiday to travel with the band. He had terrible problems but he stuck with it as long as he and she could. We have to remember that Billie had a hard time and she was happy to quit because it was just too damn tough.

MR: It wasn't just in the south either, was it?

GA: No it was I understand pretty much everywhere, but worse in the south of course. That's a period where I was in school so I didn't observe that particularly. I never saw Billie on stage with Artie Shaw for example, but I did see Roy Eldridge performing in person with Gene Krupa and there was always a little bit of a stir when Roy came down front to do a vocal duet with Anita O'Day. People would say, "Hey look at that, look, he's going to sing with her. Well that's pretty damn naive. Of course we guys who were interested in jazz were completely cool about all that, but it was funny to see what would happen. And even — well I shouldn't say even because this went on for a long time — in the early 40s when I was in the southern Army camp and I was a private at the time in Basic Training, Louis Armstrong came down to the Army camp town I should say, and I went to the performance which was in a dance hall actually. And I was sent upstairs with all the other white people who wanted to hear Louis, and the black audience stayed downstairs. And then I went down and said I would like to say hello to Mr. Armstrong in the dressing room, and there was a beefy cop there who told me what did I want do that for, boy. And I said well he's a friend of mine. And that was a terrible mistake. Well I mean he didn't beat up on me or anything but he looked at me with such disgust. He said, "Well you can't go there. Beat it." And so I didn't get a chance to say hello to Louis, whom I knew slightly of course. But we had become very good friends because when I started the research for the Hot Jazz Classic series on Columbia, one of the early things that I discovered was a whole batch of unreleased Armstrongs and I identified most of the personnel quite easily, but one of them I only could detect about four musicians that I could recognize, including Earl Hines of course and so I took the test pressing to New York when I knew that Louis was playing at the Apollo Theater and he invited me to come backstage. I first was told he was in the Braddock bar having lunch with his friends. And he said, "Come on backstage, I've got a phonograph." I didn't realize at that time that he carried a little portable wind-up machine with a — he always had a tape recorder and record player with him after that once the electrical equipment was developed, and he listened to the record and boy was he happy. He says oh this is wonderful, yeah, that's Stump Evans and that's so-and-so, that's the Carroll Dickerson orchestra. And from that moment on he took a great liking to me, and I remember very shortly afterwards I dropped in on him in New York again, and he said, "Hey, let's go get some ice cream and we'll pick up my darling." And I didn't know what he meant by his "darling," because he was married at the time to Alpha, but they were in the process of breaking up. And this darling turned out to be Lucille Wilson, who was the last Mrs. Armstrong and his widow eventually, and he got a quart of ice cream, vanilla ice cream, and we took it to Mrs. Wilson's apartment, her mother, and Lucille was a dancer at the Lafayette Theater. And I found out later that she had broken some new territory because Lucille was darker than

most of the chorus girls. That color business always held forth in the black night clubs in Harlem. They wanted light skinned girls.

MR: The bronze-skinned.

GA: That's it, the bronze-skinned beauties, sepia beauties, and all the — what's the word, not cliches, the subterfuge type words, I can't think of the exact word but you know what I mean. And so we enjoyed the ice cream there and Louis polished it off, he was amazing, he had about two-thirds of that quart of ice cream himself. And from that time on, he treated me almost like a member of his musical family. And I remember as we left the house he went down about three or four steps from the apartment and I was parked right in front there, and before he got in the car he stood at the top of the steps and did a little pirouette. And he said, "Oh my God my darling, my darling, she's so sweet, my darling." And I thought my God, Louis Armstrong is revealing his inner soul to me, a student.

MR: Yeah. What a moment.

GA: Oh it was terrific. I realized then that Louis really liked me, and our friendship lasted forever. He used to call up and say, "Hey I'm laying off a couple of days, come on out to the house and bring your brother with you," because he loved my brother too.

MR: Now you said Miles said the same thing to you.

GA: Well yes as a matter of fact Miles was that way too. It was a little different because Miles was much more reserved you know. Louis was what you see. I mean he was just an open-hearted soul, and all this baloney about the Uncle Toms and so on, well Louis felt that his mission was to make people happy. And he learned that in New Orleans as a boy, and he kept that attitude all his life. And so he was just being himself. Miles was different because Miles was a kind of a lonesome person and he had a very sweet side to him which he hid afterwards as he got better known and put on that facade of being the tough guy.

MR: The "dark prince."

GA: Yeah, the "dark prince" business yeah. Well it worked very well for him. But he developed it really over a period of time. And because he was a kind of a lonesome person and he was always ailing, you know there was always something wrong with Miles. He had problems with his bones, he had eventually diabetes, he had everything it seems. And when he wasn't doing too much he would occasionally call up and say hey come on over to the house and hang out. And he had nothing particularly to talk about but he just enjoyed having some company. And in later years, when he was really ill, my brother and I would think of calling him up and seeing if we could come over you know, and we would do that. And one day I called Miles, my brother was I guess working on a movie out of town or something. And I said, "Hey what's happening" and all, and said, "Can I come over?" He said, "Sure, come on." And after a little while he said, "Well

George, what do you want?" I said, "What do you mean what do I want?" "Well does Ar want me to do a movie soundtrack for him or something?" I said, "No, no, no." Well he said, "Well I thought you wanted me for something." I said, "No, we're just friends, I came over to see how you were, I heard you weren't feeling well." And it took him a little while to realize that that was the only reason that I'd called him up. I realized also at that time that when people would call up to come over and talk to Miles, they were people that wanted something out of him, and I didn't. And he respected that.

MR: He had become a money making commodity.

GA: Yes he did. Well he worked at that too, because Miles was very aware, once he began to build his reputation, which came about really through the explosive impact of the "Miles Ahead" album, which was a campaign that clicked beautifully, but we won't talk about that, that's been talked about elsewhere. The fact that he felt that he was more deserving of reputation and even income than he received put him in the frame of mind where he deliberately went out and bought rock music records, especially by the British groups that were getting to be leaders in the field, and that's how he patterned himself for the electric period of Miles Davis, and he never totally achieved what he thought he might achieve in terms of reputation and financial gain but it worked beautifully for him anyway, and that's the way he acquired independence, which increased his independent attitude. And he was never really a happy man I'm sorry to say, but then happiness is I guess coming to terms with yourself and all that sort of thing. Armstrong was a happy man. My goodness. I've got to stop talking about Louis, but after he died I became more and more aware of what a great person he was as a human being.

MR: Well you know when you look at the fact that he seemed to just get pleasure out of spending all that time writing to people. They have all those letters he wrote.

GA: Oh that's right.

MR: That pretty much shows what a caring person he was I think.

GA: Well I'm glad you said that because I keep forgetting to tell people that, when they talk about Louis and being an Uncle Tom and so forth. I've said many times, look, that's the way he was, he loved people. And do you sit down and write long letters to people that you don't see very often? Well he did it all the time. He wrote letters every day of his life. I'm ashamed to say that I left I think all but one or two of his letters in the files of Columbia Records when I left, and they disappeared or they're in the hands of other people Some of them have been given to Rutgers I believe and Tulane, but not much was preserved. Maybe somebody's got them stashed away somewhere, I hope so. There weren't that many but I should have been thoughtful enough to really clean things out before I left the office the last day. But it was something which was not primarily on my mind at the time. I left behind hundreds of test pressings which have been sold to

collectors and I'm happy to say in some cases donated to archives like the Louis Armstrong Archive at Queens College, which is an incredible repository because Armstrong left everything, as a collection, to Queens College to preserve for all time. And Michael Cogswell has done a terrific job as curator of that collection.

MR: Yeah. He must have had an incredible energy also, because I did visit there and when you look at all the things he did with his tapes you know, just decorating the boxes and all that, like he was never without something to do.

GA: That's right. He was always busy. And one of the things that kind of shocked me after he showed me more of his things than I'd seen before was that he had acquired this scotch tape which came in big sheets, and he would put those big sheets of scotch tape over photographs and everything. And my brother finally told him, "You know Pops, you've got to stop using this because the material that makes it adhesive is very harmful to the surface of photographs for example, and you will never be able to peel things away and you'll find that these clippings that are underneath the surface of this fancy scotch tape will start deteriorating. So he stopped doing that. But he was really an art director. If you go to the archive, Michael and his assistant George Arevelo are very happy to show people around if they're not too busy, and if they get a phone call in advance they make the time. It's absolutely fabulous. He makes montages which make a great deal of sense from the art point of view. He could have been a graphic artist very easily because he was a communicator. That was the big thing about Louis. He was a communicator from the word go.

MR: To take this idea into a kind of a current aspect, this kind of racial divisions that happened, sometimes not from the musicians but from outside. What do you see is the racial outlook of jazz today?

GA: Well the sad part about it is that there's a great deal of division, and it continues in a fairly subtle way. I wish it weren't so because there's a lot of talk about how color doesn't mean anything in jazz, but unfortunately it does and it has since well really I guess it started just before World War II, and there was a kind of a movement when the bop musicians started to establish themselves, to ostracize white musicians to the point where it got to be harder and harder for white musicians to find work. Now the justification was supposed to be that well, black musicians never got the breaks when it came to working, and that was certainly true. But jazz broke that down so that it became far, far easier. The problem was so bad that apart from the horror stories of bands traveling through the south, there was never a major hotel, which was a great venue for the dance bands, which opened up until maybe around 1940, for bands like Count Basie, Jimmy Lunceford and goodness knows for many years Fletcher Henderson and all that. There was even segregation in ballrooms although that broke down in Harlem when the

Savoy Ballroom began to bring in white bands. In any event, it has reached the point where today there are very, very fine white musicians who can't really find work and that especially holds in Europe where there was always a feeling of the, what shall we say, the romance and I don't know the word exactly, the glamour of the primitive black man and his primitive music. That's the way the early jazz fans seemed to look at jazz. And once that got washed away and people realized well that's an inaccurate description. Nevertheless, in Europe the emphasis on wanting to go hear black musicians continued to the point where white musicians have a pretty hard time getting bookings at many of the festivals. And it happens even in the United States. In clubs for example, there are a lot of good white musicians who can't break in because the club owners and the audiences seem to want to hear black musicians. I hate to carry on about this because race to me is a ridiculous thing to have a problem about, but I'm simply saying what exists.

MR: From what I see, and please correct me if I'm wrong, it seems like the mainstream tradition that's being carried on in jazz today is mostly the white musicians — Ken Peplowski and Randy —

GA: Oh yes it's certainly true. But there's a reason for it, which is a very unfortunate one. And that is that the younger white musicians don't know the foundation of what they consider their music. They simply don't go into it and—

MR: I'm sorry, the younger white musicians?

GA: The younger black musicians, did I say white? The younger black musicians don't know the origins of jazz and they don't know say the New Orleans tradition except for those who are down in New Orleans. A great example of the positive side of a young black musician knowing the foundation of the music is Nicholas Payton. I consider Nicholas to be the outstanding young jazz musician in the world today, by a considerable margin, and one reason is that he not only knows the music from the beginning on, but he can play it. I mean he plays Louis Armstrong and the early New Orleans pioneers and the swing people to perfection and he is also the closest thing I've heard to say Clifford Brown. He knows the whole bop era and he plays it. When he plays in person, whatever happens, you can hear the whole history of jazz because he basically plays the modern aspect of jazz but then he dips into the earlier music as well. And the most striking example of that was the few performances he made in New York in which he had guests on different nights during the week that he played say at the Iridium. He would have Clark Terry for one or two nights, and then he would have Doc Cheatham for one or two nights, and so his sets were like a kind of history of jazz in which he would start out with his modern group and then gradually get back into the past of jazz, not all the way back of course. And out of that came a wonderful recording which won a Grammy award thank

goodness, and that was the duet album with Doc Cheatham and the performance of "Stardust." I can't even talk about it.

MR: I know. It's great to listen.

GA: I'm so happy that it happened, and it happened under odd circumstances. It almost didn't happen but there was a lady named Andrea — oh God all of a sudden I'm drawing a blank on her last name, it's a very nice French name, she's from New Orleans — and she was the one who thought of the idea and pushed it though. And she represented Doc Cheatham in his later years, actually managing him out of New Orleans. Anyway you can get the story of that basically from the CD, which is one of the most delightful records in recent years.

MR: Yesterday I had asked you a question about if the early jazz musicians thought of their music as an art form. And you said probably not.

GA: No not really. They were just playing happy music that they had developed within their lives, and they were happy making a living at it as best they could in many cases of course. Because a jazz musician's life has never been easy unless you happen to hit it big. But I don't think musicians ever took it seriously as an art form until they were told it was an art form, and that probably started, I think it would have to be during the World War II years. Because before there weren't any articles being written in magazines, God knows no books to speak of, but once that started, quite a bit of pretension did begin to creep in. And some of it spurred I feel the bop movement because that was something new and hard to understand compared to the relative ease of listening to the earlier music because that was, among other things, dance music, social music, good time music, popular songs were involved. Bop became something which for the most part did not depend on familiar standard selections, even though a lot of the earlier compositions were simply variations on the harmonies which were themselves altered along the way, of standard tunes by Gershwin and Cole Porter and so forth. So it became a kind of an inside arty thing. And this was encouraged by the people who wrote about jazz because more and more writing about jazz took place in magazines. The writers began to create feuds I feel, and I wasn't particularly involved in it because this started while the war was going on and I was drafted very early, in '41, and ended up out in the Phillipines invasion and all that and didn't get back until the occupation of Japan was well underway. I came back from Japan in February 1946. And so I missed a lot of that. Of course I got to see articles, even overseas, people would send me things when it was possible to do so, and then the Army also had little pocket editions of *Down Beat* magazine for example for soldiers. I wish I'd saved some of them.

MR: It's interesting that the music was considered enough of a popular entity that that would be something.

GA: Oh definitely. The Army Special Services, which was the branch that took care of morale and so forth, managed to get even V-discs over to the Phillipines and I copped a few for myself which I wasn't supposed to do, and hid them in my barracks bag and brought some back home actually. And V-discs were quite remarkable. They were twelve-inch flexible vinylite records, had to be in order to survive transportation and so forth, and the Army or Navy, Marine Corps, all received copies of these recordings and they were used mainly in the centers where there were recreational facilities for the soldiers, and that's how I swiped a few. They were either copied from released records, but more and more they were made especially for our armed forces, in studios and performances and so on. Collectors are really quite into this whole thing and there are some wonderful performances, but that's a different matter, we won't go into it.

MR: Did you personally have — I don't want to say a problem — how did you adjust in your thinking and listening to the bop movement?

GA: Oh that was a kind of an interesting thing because I was already aware of what was beginning to happen before the war. You see I got drafted straight off the campus, I was inducted about two or three months after I graduated from Yale. The first inkling was in the form of Dizzy Gillespie's playing. And I first heard Dizzy in I guess it was 1938 because I remember discussing it with Marshall Stearns. His records came out and there were solos of Dizzy's on various releases, including of course the Cab Calloway Orchestra, and when I got to meet Dizzy it was with Marshall. And I remember Marshall talking to Dizzy. This was in his apartment actually after hours, after a performance in New Haven. And Marshall said, "You know Dizzy on this record you made" — I wish I could remember which one it is — "well you play this figure [scats] what's the idea behind it?" Dizzy laughed and said, "Oh I thought it was commercial." Well that broke us up, that Dizzy was probably kidding but at the same time Dizzy was very conscious of the fact that he was doing something different and this was attracting attention to himself. Now I know that this had to be as early as 1938 or '39 because Marshall got his Ph.D. and I drove out to California to take his car to Los Angeles and put it on a boat so that he could take it to the University of Hawaii, his first posting with a professorship. And so this had to happen before that trip. And that's pretty early on for this kind of thing to begin to really take hold. I don't think there was — well the word "bop" hadn't come into the picture yet. But more and more there was exposure of this sort. And then when I went away into the armed forces and only got back to New York for very short periods for a couple of years and then not at all when I was overseas, I would hear about what was happening and there were inklings of it on the V-discs of course. And when I came back I went from landing in Seattle to Los Angeles because my sister had gotten married to someone that we knew just before the war, he was a Colonel in the Air Force who got

discharged relatively early, in fact he got discharged when his squadron was brought back to the United States from Europe in order to fly out immediately to Japan and then they were told when they were ready to go, well we don't need you out there and those of you who have had enough service can get discharged. And that's when he married my sister and moved out to Los Angeles, his home. So with the permission of my parents, who were very nice about it when I called up in Seattle and said, "Hi Mom and Pop I'm back, can I go visit Mary," my sister, "before I come home?" Because they always said if you want to do that you're entitled to it, you're allowed a stopover. The reason I got into all this is that when I arrived, Ross Russell, who had a record shop in a small record label that he'd just started, Dial Records, was someone I'd met before I went overseas, and he'd been corresponding with me and told me about the growth of the bop movement around Los Angeles. And when I called up Ross he said, "Hey you came just in time, Gillespie and Parker have a quintet at Billy Berg's and we'll go tomorrow night if you're free." I said fine. That was my first exposure to live bebop. And it was very lively, believe me, and it was very unusual because the records that I had heard were not really indicative of the music that I heard that night. So I heard the group maybe once more before I went back to New York and that was my real introduction to bop. It was puzzling but it wasn't that far out as we know now by listening to the records. For some people it was very violently different. Now when I got back home, I called up Ted Wallerstein, the president of Columbia Records, I never called him Ted, he was Mr. Wallerstein, believe me, a wonderful man but rather austere and he was the man who hired me to do that great series of the Hot Jazz Classics reissues. He said, "George, you know you're being drafted and you have to be in the Army for year" that was the way it went before the war reached the United States. "At the end of the year if your father allows you do so, instead of going into the family business because he knew my father wanted me to do that, I wanted you to know you'd be welcome, we'd like to have you back." And I said, "Gee thank you sir." And so four and a half years later I called him up and said, "Well I'm back and if that offer still holds, I'd love to come work for Columbia Records full time." And he said to me, "Well did you ask your father, what did he say?" I said, "Oh my father said, 'George you deserve to have a little fun. If you want to do that go right ahead and when you want to get serious with your life, come in to the family business,'" which I did 25 years later when my dad was quite old and wanted me to come in, and I felt like it because I got kind of fed up with the changes in the record business. Not things like bop and all, but the commercial aspect and the fact that accountants and lawyers took over the running of the companies, and people weren't very interested in music anymore. It still holds today I'm sorry to say, despite the lip service, despite everything you read in publications, *Jazz Times*, *DownBeat*, and so on. Money is the bottom line. There are

people there who don't really have that much interest in music, no matter how much they talk about it. But the big thing is that having had this miniature exposure as it grew, I got exposed more and more to what was happening in the New York club scene and so forth, and recording wise I wasn't too keen on getting into it. Well first of all you have to remember that in '47, a year after I got into the record business, I was not only just a junior producer of the pop singles of the day, there wasn't any album business to speak of, but Mr. Wallerstein put me in charge of popular albums and also when the director of the International Department retired at sixty some-odd, I was put in charge of that department too because of my foreign background and interest in standard music, you know the music of Gershwin, and Porter and Youmans and so forth. That was valuable in running the pop album department. And of course my interest in foreign music and my knowledge of languages made me a natural for the International Department. Now you have to remember both departments were microscopic. That's why I was given those jobs. Nobody else wanted them. But Mr. Wallenstein knew that they were trying to develop a long playing records, and when they did in '48, 50 years ago, I was sitting in a remarkable position. Between us Howard Scott, who was another young producer in the Masterworks Department, and I produced the first 100 pop and 100 classical LPs and we never knew that it was going to be so big. It got to be big of course in classical music right away. But on the pop side, the ten-inch LP was not too meaningful because it was not an album business for popular music. It became that in '53, and I won't describe the process because there are many factors which had nothing to do with music, which made a twelve-inch pop LP so big in terms of sales volume and interest by the public, and of course the changes in what was recorded and how it was presented to the public, that it totally revised the way the record business was run on the pop side. Instead of the emphasis being just on single records and pop hits to drive the pop sales, and the activity of recording pop music, it became a packaging concept with all kinds of — if I may say so — much higher quality content than the hit single of the day philosophy, which was the force behind the pop record business until LP started to take over. The international side grew enormously because of this. The foreign affiliates that American companies had were not too interested in most of the classical music because the classical music market in Europe was so much bigger than pop music was, compared to the way it was in America, so they didn't need to have very much in the way of classical music coming over from the United States. The pop performers that they preferred were people that they had seen in movies like Frank Sinatra and Doris Day. But then the burgeoning interest in jazz that had already begun before the war created a market for jazz LPs in Europe which was quickly fed by jazz musicians going to Europe, which was not an ordinary thing until air travel really got established in the early 50s. And from then on, the American pop

albums became more and more important in Europe and finally Japan. When I left Columbia Records in 1958, Europe was bringing in almost as much money in the album sales to the American originators as the domestic sales were. And when Japan got on board, which was really about 1960 I would say, Japan ended up being bigger than Europe. Now all of this international business was made possible through the long playing record, and jazz was an important part of it. It isn't anymore and hasn't been for many years because the rock musicians in England helped change that, the interest in jazz began dropping off. But to this day jazz musicians make a better living playing in Japan and Europe than they do in the United States, which is a tragic thing but that's the way it is.

MR: In your career as a producer, did you have a philosophy about when you approached a new artist you hadn't worked with before about how to produce them?

GA: Yes. The basic idea was very, very simple. How can I help the artist present himself in the most effective way for his benefit as well as of course the company? But in many cases there was a matter of what do you do to make the artist appealing to the potential record customer, and most of the time the artist had no idea except that man I just want to blow you know. And that's why it became important as everything grew more and more competitive to find ways of presenting artists, including jazz artists, in a way that will stand out. One of the classic examples of course is Miles Davis because Miles was constantly performing with small groups, quintet, sextet, and the music was more or less of the same except for the variety within it, and when I signed Miles I had a very strange problem. Miles persuaded me to sign him while he was still under contract to Prestige Records, because he was dying to get on Columbia, where he knew that he would get a lot more exposure. And he finally convinced me that he was not only off the drugs and so forth and was becoming reliable, which he certainly wasn't to the extent that he had no manager, he had no booking agent who would really work seriously with him because he was considered so risky. I realized that the way to handle it is to figure out a program whereby we could record him for a year and a half without permission to release him because of his contract with Prestige. They allowed us to do that, a very unusual contract. And how could he keep on working and building himself up to the point where he would mean something when we were able to launch him on the label. And the solution was to convince Miles that he should try to form a group that could stick together and even though that group would primarily record for Prestige, I would able to record it also. And to hold it together he needed management. He had a manager who was really a friend of his, but he needed a strong booking agency, and I got him Jack Wittemore, who was with the Shaw Artists Agency, and I told Jack if Miles can form a group and you can hold it together, I think we can really do something when he's on the Columbia label. And that's

what happened. Miles was fortunate enough to get the original quintet together very quickly in September '55. I went to hear them for the first time in Philadelphia when he called and said, "Hey, I've got these terrific guys: Coltrane— and Coltrane was just a name to me, I'd never even heard him — Philly Joe Jones and Paul Chambers and Red Garland, well I knew them of course. And he did hold them together and Wittemore did do a terrific job of booking them when there were no Columbia records to back them up so that when we got the first album out "Round Midnight" — which commemorated the performance of the song at Newport — I'd already told Miles before that release look we've got to do something different. And of course Miles was just interested in getting out and playing. And that's how the idea of Gil Evans' arrangements came about. And the title of the album, I told Miles and Gil is going to be "Miles Ahead," so give me an original composition, we'll make a DJ single of that and some of the other selections because the album as you know, is done as a complete suite, continuous. So for DJs we had to put out the separate singles. And I told the art director the album is going to be called "Miles Ahead," what can you give me as a cover that will say Miles is ahead of everybody else and Miles is moving ahead, he's miles ahead of everything. And he came up with that sailboat photograph, which he'd got from an agency which tells the story, you look past the girl and the sailboat, she's miles ahead of everybody, there's nothing but blue sky and blue ocean behind her, she's winning the race. She doesn't look like she's racing but she's attractive. And that whole promotion worked like a dream. That album sold unbelievably and established Miles all over the world. Miles hated the cover of course because it was a white girl.

MR: Well it's a pretty astute balance of artistic and commercial concerns.

GA: Well that's true you had to do that in order to stand out. Now I don't like to talk against competition but take Norman Granz's operation which was eventually the Verve label and all. Norman made a tremendous number of records but his approach was basically to just bring the guys into the studio or record them on stage, and then figure out what to do about packaging and there was never any really concept in any of the albums. I'm sorry to single out Norman, but it's an easy target for this idea of you can go two ways. Just record artists and put the records out hoping that something will hit, and then the other way is to try to record them in a way in which there is an idea behind it which will attract the customer. Eventually, since I — I shouldn't have done this but it's not being publicly broadcast so I don't feel so bad — I will say this that Norman ended up recognizing this and that's when he got into the series of the Ella Fitzgerald Songbook, Ella sings Richard Rodgers and so on and so on. Those were the pop conceptions that other people like myself were doing a long time ago. And it worked very well so that these are now classic

albums that have an identity and significance within simply themselves, instead of just being part of the body of work of an artist.

MR: Well you know we're going to have to do a Part Two, maybe in New York or something when we come there.

GA: I'll tell you Monk, when I get rolling, it doesn't stop, and I haven't said a tenth of the things that I was thinking of saying.

MR. But I very much would like to get together with you again if it's okay with you when we get to New York.

GA: We certainly will do it.

MR: What's in the near future for you?

GA: Well that's a good question because the near future for years has been write the God damn book. I have friends who send me big printouts from their computers, WRITE THAT BOOK and I have it on the wall. But the trouble is it's so hard, interruptions constantly and I'm always being asked to help people. Last night the waitress at the place where I went with the guys from Colgate was a very sweet, attractive girl, and I guess she found out who I was, and she asked me for guidance on her own career which was as a singer/ guitarist, and she's a member of a little group, her husband is the lead guitarist and so on, and I said, "Gee, it's impossible to give advice to anyone just bang like that, I don't know what you're doing." I can imagine what it is, and it's not my area anyway, but I was able to give her one piece of advice which sounds rather routine but it works: do what you want to do the best that you can, and get as much exposure as you can and stick to it. And it's really the best advice you can give anybody who is a performer. And it sounds simplistic but what else can you do when you start out? That's how everybody starts out. And looking at my own life I'm amazed that I was so lucky to be an enthusiastic fan who suddenly got to hear the whole history of the music that he had gotten interested in in high school, because Marshall Stearns had one of the world's great record collections, even though it fit into a closet, there weren't that many records. And then I was lucky enough to be writing and get a reputation that persuaded Columbia Records to ask me, a student, to go the 23 miles or so from New Haven to Bridgeport where the factory was and research the material for the series. And it just went on like that. To be in the right place at the right time, and also to be working the best you can at what you're interested in and suddenly create a career. I never thought I'd be in the music business but there I was. I wanted to be an English teacher.

MR: We're glad you were and are still.

GA: I am too.

MR: So I hope you find some time for that book.

GA: I've got to do it.

MR: And it's been a great pleasure for me to talk to you.

GA: The pleasure is really mine. Thank you.

MR: All right. Thank you.